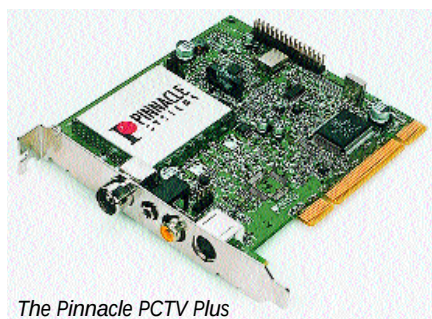
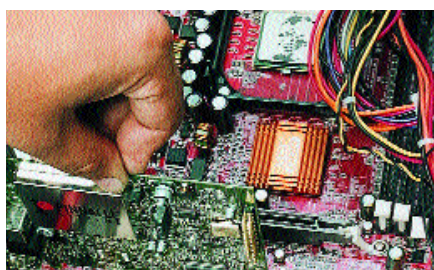




The Pinnacle PCTV Plus



Inserting the TV Tuner card

whole card and lock it down with a screw. You can now close the computer.

Connect the equipment: Before you load the software, hook up the cables into the card. There will be directions for this in the card's manuals, but here's generally what you have to do. Connect the coaxial cable (from the cable TV line) into the cable/antenna socket. Also, connect the cables from the card to your soundcard. The external interface is easily connected—hook up the 3.5 mm jack into the Audio Out on the TV Tuner card and on the other end, into the Line In connector for the soundcard.

Having done this, boot up your computer. As Windows loads up, it will detect your card and prompt you for the card drivers. Insert the driver CD and follow the instructions on screen.

3, 2, 1... PVR!

A PVR software may be bundled along with the card, but it would be better to use a dedicated third-party PVR software for higher control and functionality. Cyberlink PowerVCR II has an attractive interface, is highly configurable and the codecs that come bundled with it are fast and deliver good quality video. Before installation, check for any known conflicts (see box, 'Tweak Me!').

Install the software: Install the PVR software and follow the directions on screen. The installation program will then locate a working directory on the drive that has the maximum free space. You will need a minimum of 500 MB for a 10

PowerVCR: What's Where?

Main Panel

- Live/Digital Recorder
- Instant TV Replay
- PowerDVD
- File Player
- Recording Scheduler
- File Converter
- Video Trimmer
- DV Tape Transcoder (DV to MPEG)
- iPower

The Main Interface

Channel surfing

Video Panel

PowerVCR Panel

ON/OFF switch

Settings

Help

Indicates time recorded / space usage on the hard disk

Volume Control

TV tuner control

Playback controls

minute replay buffer to view 10 minutes of real time TV. You should optimally keep at least 1 GB for this working directory and additional space for saving video footage. After this, the software will run a couple of diagnostic tests and recommend some settings based on it. Since capturing video feed is a stressful exercise on the subsystem, we suggest you tweak your hardware settings to get the best out of it (see box, *Tweak Me!*).

PowerVCR comes bundled with PowerDVD. This is very useful if you have a DVD-ROM drive, as PowerDVD is one of the best DVD playback tools available. The install program will also give you the option of installing the Intel Indeo codecs. **Configuring the software:** Before starting the software, make sure that the cable line is plugged in firmly. Also check and see if the audio connectors are in place.

PowerVCR is made of three primary elements—the main panel, the video display and the PowerVCR panel. The main panel will let you switch between PowerVCR, PowerDVD, Recording, Editing, and Live/Replay as well as File play modes of the software. The Video display panel shows the video feed as is received by the TV Tuner card. Finally, the PowerVCR panel comes with controls to switch between channels, play and stop the video (buffered or on file) and increase and decrease volume levels (see 'PowerVCR: What's Where?').

When you start PowerVCR for the first



Tweak Me!

Capturing, encoding and storing video footage is quite stressful for your computer. These are the tweaks that will help you on your road to PVR bliss.

DMA: Enabling DMA (Direct Memory Access) for hard disk drives and CD-ROM drives results in freeing up the CPU during read/write operations. To enable DMA, right-click on My Computer and choose Properties. Open the Device Manager tab and expand the Disk drives tree. Choose your hard drive and click on Properties. Under Settings, check the DMA option. Windows 98 may have a small warning popping up. Don't worry about it and select close. Repeat the same with your CD-ROM drives. Restart. DMA should now be enabled. If DMA is not enabled, check if your BIOS, hard drive and CD-ROM drive support DMA.

Drivers: Get the latest drivers for your graphics card from the vendor's Web site. Most PVR software require DirectX drivers, which you can download from Microsoft's Web site. Also, check with the TV Tuner card's manual and Web site to see if there are any known conflicts with your graphics card drivers, and install patches for these. Also install the codecs for converting raw video footage into an appropriate format.